

NOCTURNE

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FADE IN:

EXT. NOCTURNE LTD. HEADQUARTERS – NIGHT

Rain hammers Tokyo. AKIRA KAWASAKI (26) stands barefoot outside a nondescript corporate building, soaked through silk into skin. She's been staring at the entrance for eleven minutes.

The facade is forgettable – the kind of building designed to be passed without seeing. But she sees it. A wall-mounted display glows behind the glass: PARTICIPATION IS VOLUNTARY. NOCTURNE LTD. IS NOT LIABLE UNDER NATIONAL OR INTERNATIONAL JURISDICTION.

Her phone is wiped. Her apartment lease is void. The email she sent three hours ago has already detonated inside the Kawasaki Group. There is no version of tomorrow where her name still means what it meant yesterday.

The buzzer glows red. Waiting.

Akira closes her eyes. She breathes in the sound of the rain, the warmth of the last free street, the smell of the city at night. Memorizing. Then she presses.

The door clicks open.

INT. FACILITY – LOBBY – NIGHT

Fluorescent. Cold. No reception desk. REI MIKAMI (30s) waits in a pressed suit. Pen in hand. The smile he gives her is thin. Professional.

The wall-mounted display glitches. For a split second, a black glyph – ancient, insect-like – flashes across the screen: □□.

Akira tenses. Not recognition – the instinct to.

REI

Ignore that. Just legacy code. Old systems bleeding through.

The screen clears. Clean corporate blue.

INT. FACILITY – HALLWAY – MOMENTS LATER

Long corridor. White tile, stainless steel. The buzz of electricity hums beneath the silence.

REI
Phones. Wallet. Identification.

Akira hands him everything without protest. Even the necklace
— a tiny jade cicada.

REI (CONT'D)
Sentimental?

AKIRA
It was my sister's.

REI
Not anymore.

He drops it into a plastic envelope. Seals it. She watches it
disappear — the last piece of a life she's choosing to leave.
Her fingers linger in the air where it was, then close into a
fist.

INT. INDUCTION ROOM — NIGHT

A room meant to look medical but not sterile. YUMI TAKEDA
(late 20s) stands behind a terminal. Unsmiling. Her hair is
too neat. Her nails too clean.

YUMI
Strip down to underclothes.

Akira takes her time. Blazer. Blouse. Skirt. Each item folded
precisely.

Yumi passes a scanner over Akira's body. Data flickers —
brainwave graphs, thermal overlays.

YUMI (CONT'D)
No pacemaker. No pregnancy. No
record of psychiatric detainment.

REI
Physical trauma. Lower left
thoracic scarring.

AKIRA
Knife.

YUMI
Yours?

AKIRA
(a breath)
No.

Rei slides a folder toward her. Thick. Paper-clipped.

REI
Sign and thumbprint. You may choose
to speak a final sentence into
record.

Akira flips through it. Her eyes pause at the MOTIVE field.
Her pen hovers.

AKIRA
I was the wrong story in the right
family.

She signs. Presses her thumb.

YUMI
Transfer begins now.

A door slides open. Faint sound of rain. No exit sign.

Akira walks forward. Doesn't look back.

INT. OBSERVATION SUITE — NIGHT

Yumi and Rei watch monitors as Akira disappears into the
corridor.

YUMI
She doesn't know.

REI
None of them do.

Yumi closes the terminal. Her hand lingers a moment too long.

YUMI
(soft)
I was like you once. Before I
chose.

INT. TRANSFER CORRIDOR — NIGHT

Dim, narrow. Metallic hum. Akira walks flanked by silent
attendants.

Up ahead — another subject. Male. Mid-30s. Sweating. Shaking.
He sees Akira and SNAPS.

SUBJECT
No — NO! This isn't what they said!

He lands an elbow into one attendant's throat. Chaos erupts. Screams. A security strobe hits.

The subject locks eyes with Akira. Bloody. Wild.

SUBJECT (CONT'D)
Don't let them-

He's yanked backward. His scream cuts off.

Silence returns. Akira blinks. And keeps walking.

INT. COMMON ROOM - LATER

A cafeteria space. Pale wood. Soft music. Everyone is smiling. Too still.

Yumi leads Akira to a small circular table. A WOMAN (20s, polite, blank) sits with folded hands.

WOMAN
Relocation due to stalker
harassment. Duration, indefinite.
I'm grateful to be here.

As Yumi moves behind the woman - the woman's lips shift. Barely audible.

WOMAN (CONT'D)
(whispers)
Get out. They're MUKUROKAI.

Akira freezes. The woman's smile resumes as if it never left.

INT. THE WHISPER ROOM - NIGHT

A small booth. Eggshell walls. The door seals with a pneumatic hiss.

First: SHIN'S VOICE.

SHIN (V.O.)
You should learn to keep secrets...

Akira winces.

Then her sister.

SISTER (V.O.)
Did you forget me?

A low-frequency hum begins. Vibrational. Her fingernails twitch.

Then a third voice. Genderless. Inhuman.

VOICE (V.O.)
MUKUROKAI is watching.

It sounds like it's coming from inside her lungs.

The door slides open. Yumi stands there.

YUMI
Longer than most.

INT. TRANSITION CHAMBER — NIGHT

A narrow room of obsidian black. The floor pulses faintly beneath Akira's feet.

YUMI
Final clearance requires silence.

AKIRA
I thought I passed.

YUMI
That was compliance. This is
surrender. Step forward.

Akira does. The hum deepens.

YUMI (CONT'D)
Name?

Akira looks at Yumi. Holds her gaze. The protocol has no response for what she does next.

AKIRA
You first.

Yumi's breath catches. For one unguarded second the mask drops — not the professional one, the personal one. She was once someone else too.

The power dynamic between them shifts. It is no longer vertical.

YUMI
(recovering, quiet)
Welcome home.

INT. AKIRA'S ASSIGNED APARTMENT — NIGHT

Spartan. Generic feminine touches applied like paint. A silk scarf draped. A pink toothbrush. A photo of friends she doesn't know.

Akira sits on the bed. The ID card reads SHIORI TAKADA in flawless Helvetica. She runs her thumb across it. Again. And again.

INT. SURVEILLANCE ROOM — NIGHT

Rei watches the feed. Akira sleeps on her side, ID card clutched in her hand.

He scrubs back the footage. A FLICKER. Behind her — a shadow where no shape should be.

Her reflection in the dark glass faces the camera.

He encrypts the file. Labels it: CAT R - 01 / Echo.

INT. DIAGNOSTIC LAB — NIGHT

Yumi scrolls through Akira's neural feedback. Two files overlay — current scan and archival.

Akira's scan is complex. Unstable. But beneath it: something too ordered. An emergent symmetry.

On-screen, an abstract symbol emerges embedded in the EEG output: □□ KUROKAMI.

YUMI
(quietly)
That's not... possible.

A TECHNICIAN enters. Freezes.

TECHNICIAN
That embedded? That's not supposed
to—

YUMI
No one added it. It's recursive.
Self-generating.

She clicks deeper. Redacted pages. One word unblurred:
MUKUROKAI.

YUMI (CONT'D)
(whispered)
Mukurokai... Not again.

INT. AKIRA'S ROOM — NIGHT

Akira lies still. Something buzzes faintly.

She sits up. On her nightstand — the jade cicada. Burnt.
Ashed around the edges.

She stares. Blinks. It's gone.

The photo on the wall flickers. The people inside turn their
heads toward her.

WHISPER (V.O.)
You brought it back.

INT. BATHROOM — CONTINUOUS

She looks in the mirror. Her reflection stares back — but
delayed. Out of sync.

Then the reflection blinks.

Her reflection smiles.

The mirror CRACKS.

INT. TRANSFER CHAMBER — NIGHT

Circular. Velvet-black. A ring of light pulses beneath
Akira's feet like a halo inverted.

Yumi enters carrying a metal briefcase. Opens it. Inside: a
slim surgical device. A syringe. The fluid is black, viscous
— it shifts inside the glass, responding to warmth.

YUMI
Final conversion. You disappear so
you may be remade.

AKIRA
I didn't understand the terms.

YUMI
You understood enough.

She steps closer. The syringe catches light. Her other hand reaches for Akira's arm – fingers warm against skin. Not the grip of a handler.

AKIRA
What do I become?

YUMI
Someone we can trust.

Akira looks at Yumi's hand. At the syringe. At the woman holding it, who has done this before – to others, to herself, to someone whose face Akira keeps seeing in mirrors.

Something in Akira – not a thought, not a decision, something she couldn't stop if she wanted to – says no.

She moves.

The briefcase hits the floor. The syringe shatters. Black fluid hisses against the tile, burning faint smoke.

No alarms sound. The system does not react.

Yumi hasn't moved. Her face is stripped open – not anger, not protocol. What's behind it is fear. Not of Akira.

Of what Akira just proved is possible.

The glyph □□ flickers across the mirrored dome above. As if projected from beneath her skin.

Yumi sees it. For the first time – true fear.

CUT TO:

INT. THE FORGOTTEN CHAMBER – NIGHT

A place not on any map. Half-lit, lined with paper screens, old monitors humming with static. Incense coils like breath from a dead mouth.

Akira stands in the center. A door opens.

Yumi enters. Bare feet. White robe. Hands trembling. No clipboard.

YUMI
(soft)
You shouldn't be here.

AKIRA
Neither should you.

YUMI
They're going to find you. Erase
you. Again.

Beat.

YUMI (CONT'D)
I remember you. From before. Not
clearly. Like music behind a wall.
But I remember wanting you to
remember me.

She reaches up. Touches Akira's cheek with the back of her
fingers.

AKIRA
You helped them break me.

YUMI
I watched. I documented. I
rationalized. I told myself
protocol was mercy.

She leads Akira to the floor. They sit face to face.

YUMI (CONT'D)
If part of you still lives... if
she remembers me, then let me give
you back what I took.

Their lips meet. Not frantic. A press of memory. Of consent.
Of need.

The room goes quiet. The monitors go dark. For the first time
in this place, they are not observed.

CUT TO:

INT. MEMORY CHAMBER – NIGHT

Dark. Hushed. Holographic projectors cast a low fog. Akira
stands at the center.

SYSTEM (V.O.)
Subject 33. Initiation memory.
Timestamp redacted.

The fog solidifies. A memory forms.

A younger Akira. Smiling. Willing. Standing at the threshold
of Nocturne. Not dragged. Not drugged. Invited.

Yumi is there too. Younger. Softer. She touches Akira's hand with familiarity.

YUMI (MEMORY)
You understand what this means.

AKIRA (MEMORY)
I want to be clean.

Real Akira flinches. Her own smile – unfamiliar, grotesque – lingers before her.

The hologram shifts. A man's apartment. Professor Shin. Two bowls of curry. In this version, Akira is quiet. Compliant. She lets him wipe curry from her lip and smiles.

This is the Shin dinner – as the system wants her to remember it.

Another shift. Akira at a keyboard. Hovering over SEND. But in this version, she hesitates. Closes the laptop. Doesn't send.

That's a lie. She sent it. She sent it and the Kawasaki Group burned.

They erased the courage. They kept the shame.

STRANGER (O.S.)
She begged us. She wanted this.
Just like the others.

Akira watches every second. Catalogues every edit. Her face never changes. When the playback ends, she speaks into the silence:

AKIRA
You missed a frame.

The system doesn't know which one.

INT. TRANSIT CORRIDOR – LATER

Akira walks the corridor. A gurney is wheeled past – fast, clinical.

On it: a woman. Drugged. Pale.

She turns her head. And she looks exactly like Akira.

Then she's gone. The intersection is empty.

SUBJECT 47 (O.S.)
(soft)
You're not the first mistake.

Akira stops. Breathes.

AKIRA
(to no one)
Who was she?

The question hangs in the recycled air.

INT. INTERROGATION SUITE – NIGHT

Sterile white. Yumi enters with a black leather folder.

She slides a single page across the table. Thick paper.
Governmental.

Beneath redacted blocks: SIGNATURE: KUROKAMI, AKIRA.

The name flickers. For a frame, it reads: NAMIKO.

YUMI
You signed this the night of your
intake.

AKIRA
No, I didn't.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
I remember being blindfolded.
Strapped down. I remember the
needle. But not this.

Yumi pulls out a recording chip – thin, translucent,
biometric-sealed.

YUMI
If you'd like to challenge your
memory, you can authorize the
playback.

AKIRA
And watch a version of me ask for
this?

YUMI
We don't forge consent. We record
it.

AKIRA

No. You perform it. Like a script.
Like a death sentence no one has to
sign if the actor smiles.

A silence.

AKIRA (CONT'D)

Play it.

The chip plays. And what it shows is complicated – a younger Akira, not drugged, not coerced. Smiling. Saying "I want to be clean."

The horror isn't that they forced her. The horror is that some version of her consented.

She must now carry both truths: she was victimized AND she participated.

INT. MAINTENANCE CORRIDOR – NIGHT

Akira finds the gap in the wall. Through it she sees:

Rei and Yumi. Face to face.

REI

You pulled her footage. She's
carrying something. Or something's
carrying her.

He lifts a scalpel from his pocket.

YUMI

(flat)
Are you going to cut me?

REI

Only if you keep bleeding into the
work.

He places the scalpel in her hand.

REI (CONT'D)

Choose your loyalty, Yumi. Or we'll
choose for you.

Yumi walks out. The scalpel still in her hand.

Akira watches from the vent. Her stomach drops – not for herself. For Yumi. The scalpel in her hand, the way she didn't flinch – that's not strength. That's a woman who's been cut so many times she's stopped counting.

INT. CORRECTION CHAMBER — NIGHT

White. Erasure-white. Akira lies on the table. Wrists strapped. Ankles strapped. Padded. Designed for comfort. That's the worst part.

A reader scans her iris. Fails. Fails again. A technician injects something into the port on her neck.

Her profile appears on the monitor. ACTIVE.

Then it glitches. DECEASED. ARCHIVED. UNKNOWN. NAMIKO. KUROKAMI.

TECHNICIAN
(whispers)
She's writing back.

The straps don't release. They fall. Like they forgot what they were holding.

Akira sits up. The technicians are frozen.

She stands. The corridor outside is dark — the darkness of a system that no longer knows how to see her.

She walks. Behind her, lights die one by one.

Cameras whir. Stop. Spark.

A mirror catches her approach. Her reflection doesn't move. Then it does — it turns away before she does.

She keeps walking.

CUT TO:

INT. SUBTERRANEAN COUNCIL CHAMBER — NIGHT

Black lacquered walls. An obsidian table. Holographic sigils rotate — the Mukurokai Shadow Board.

Rei stands at the far end.

MUKUROKAI VOICES
(overlapping)
Subject Kurokami has glitched
protocol. Compromised ritual.
Defiled code.

The Ancestral Presence — bone-white sigil, soft feminine voice:

ANCESTRAL PRESENCE (V.O.)
She remembers.

REI
She was a child.

ANCESTRAL PRESENCE (V.O.)
So were we all, before pain became
clarity.

BLACK PROTOCOL: AUTHORIZED.

Rei turns to Akira – she has entered the chamber.

REI
You look like prophecy. But I
wonder if you understand what that
costs.

AKIRA
It cost everything.

REI
You didn't break the system. You
completed its loop. No more rooms.
No more numbers. You become the
code. I will kneel with you.

Akira looks at him. Studies him. Then:

AKIRA
What happened to Namiko?

Rei falters. The system has no protocol for grief. The
Ancestral Presence, for the first time, goes silent.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
You don't get to name me.

She turns. Walks out. Each step echoes like a verdict.

Rei watches her disappear. He exhales. Almost a sob.

REI
(to no one)
I was the last to survive the Meiji
purge. I thought that meant I
deserved to stay.

INT. HIDDEN BATHING CHAMBER – NIGHT

Red light. Geothermal steam. Ancient stone basin. Yumi enters
first, holding Akira's hand.

Akira is still bleeding – dried streaks across her thigh.

YUMI
(quietly)
No one comes here anymore. Not
since they automated cleansing.

She seals the door. Approaches slowly. Unclasps Akira's belt.

The robe slips. Silence. Skin marbled in scar tissue and steam.

Yumi kneels. Begins to wash Akira with a ceremonial cloth. Water pours from a bamboo spout. Every breath sounds louder.

YUMI (CONT'D)
(whispering)
Let me remember you this time.

Akira lifts Yumi's chin. They stare into each other.

AKIRA
Then don't look away.

Their mouths meet. Deep. The kind of kiss that could resurrect a person.

They move together into the water.

INT. STONE BATH – CONTINUOUS

Bodies submerge. Languid. Water ripples. Fingers trace scars. Every kiss placed like a memory being stitched.

Steam fogs everything. Except their eyes. Locked.

YUMI
Say my name.

AKIRA
(softly)
You don't need it. I remember you.

INT. HIDDEN BATHING CHAMBER – LATER

Akira stands in the shallows. Yumi kneels behind her. Dips fingers into ink.

She begins painting – slow, deliberate strokes across Akira's back. Down her spine. Symbols older than programming.

YUMI
(softly)
You don't have to do this alone.

AKIRA
I'm not.

One last stroke. Yumi steps back.

YUMI
Remember who you are.

AKIRA
I will.

Yumi exits. Silent. Leaving Akira in the hush of steam and sacred heat.

INT. THE NAMING CHAMBER — NIGHT

A stone circle. Empty but for her. Akira steps in. Completely bare. Ink-slick and glistening.

Before her: a basin of ink. A blade. A mirror.

She kneels. Breathes. Lifts the blade. Slow. Purposeful.

She carves the kanji into her thigh — 黒. Kurokami.

Not self-harm. Self-claiming. Blood mixes with ink.

Her hand shakes — not doubt, intensity. The kanji burns into her skin. For a second, she hears a child laughing. Namiko. Then silence.

She stands. Walks to the mirror. Her reflection — raw, marked, real.

She is no longer a glitch. She is a ghost with a name.

EXT. NOCTURNE PERIMETER — NIGHT

Security lights fail. Shadows cling like second skin.

Akira walks. Barefoot. Silent.

A soft metallic hiss. Something stabs her neck. A tranq dart.

Her body jerks. Three masked agents emerge. White uniforms. Surgical gloves.

HOODED AGENT
(softly)
We honor the glitch. And restore
order.

They draw a needle – not to sedate. To stop the heart.

Then – a hand grabs one agent. SNAP. Neck broken.

Yumi. Hair wild. Eyes wet with terror. She's not trained for
this, but she's decided.

Agent 2 lunges. Yumi throws herself forward. Desperate.
Ungraceful.

Akira's hand twitches. Then – violence. Her body moves
without thought. She bites deep into Agent 3's throat.

She rises. Blood dripping from her chin.

Every blow is survival. And release.

Three agents dead. Blood pools like ink.

Akira falls to her knees. Hands shaking. The taste of blood
is real and the bodies are real and nothing prepared her for
this – for the fact that she's capable of it.

Yumi holds her.

YUMI
It's done.

AKIRA
No. It's started.

INT. CONTROL NEXUS – NIGHT

Circular. Obsidian and screenlight. Akira stands at the
Primary Terminal – a forgotten relic keyed only to those who
were never meant to survive.

She places her palm on the screen. Blood. Ink. Memory.

The system stalls. Then it breathes.

INT. VARIOUS – SIMULTANEOUS

Screens flicker to life across Nocturne. A training ward –
nurses freeze. A sleep chamber – subjects stir. A glass
corridor – lights pulse.

INT. CONTROL NEXUS – CONTINUOUS

Akira types. Keys bleed. Her skin radiates.

AKIRA (V.O.)
I was born twice. Once in silence.
Once in surveillance. I was never
asked. I was only catalogued.

She uploads the full file. Ghostlike overlays flood the screens: Akira learning to obey. Akira learning to fake it. Akira watching herself vanish in a mirror.

AKIRA (V.O.)
And yet, I remember. Every touch.
Every absence. Memory is not
betrayal. It is rebellion.

INT. RITUAL DORMITORY – NIGHT

A dozen subjects rise from beds. Simultaneous. One weeps. Another laughs.

A young man carves a single word into his palm: REAL.

INT. CONTROL NEXUS – CONTINUOUS

AKIRA (V.O.)
If they taught us to forget, then
remembering is war.

All screens flicker to black. Then one line of red code bleeds across every surface: ██.

The broadcast centers on Namiko – the girl who came before. The system's first victim. Not a revolution. A memorial.

INT. NOCTURNE – MAIN SERVER CHAMBER – NIGHT

Alarms blare. Red strobes. Heat distortion.

A control board flashes: KAGUTSUCHI PROTOCOL – ENGAGED.

Flames bloom from the walls. Precision charges. The facility is collapsing.

INT. SURVEILLANCE HALL – CONTINUOUS

Yumi watches through static. Bloodied. Burned. Alive.

She slams the emergency override.

YUMI
Follow me. NOW.

INT. WARD CORRIDOR — MOMENTS LATER

Naked, trembling survivors stumble through firelit halls.
Yumi leads. A child clutches her hand.

Akira finds them in the smoke. She takes point.

They shove through a rusted hatch. Smoke pours. Survivors
collapse into moonlight. Coughing. Gasping. Alive.

The facility burns behind them like a funeral for gods.

Akira and Yumi stand together. Their hands meet. Not a kiss.
Just contact. Like passing a torch or a memory.

AKIRA
You end it. Your way.

Yumi's eyes shine — not hope. Pain. Earned.

EXT. TOKYO — PRE-DAWN

A soft wind stirs. The city glows — neon, ash, and memory.

Akira walks through the streets. Past glass. Past metal. Past
eyes that now see her.

A child looks up from a screen. The screen glitches — a
remembering.

A flower seller bows in recognition.

Akira doesn't wave. Doesn't pause.

She fades into the thinning night. Her body vanishes in
silhouette, swallowed by the pulse of the waking world.

But her presence remains.

AKIRA (V.O.)
They taught us that silence keeps
us safe.

AKIRA (V.O.)
But memory... keeps us whole.

FADE OUT.

TEXT ON SCREEN:

KUROKAMI — BLACK GODDESS

She was never a ghost. Only a name... they tried to forget.

FADE TO BLACK.

THE END.